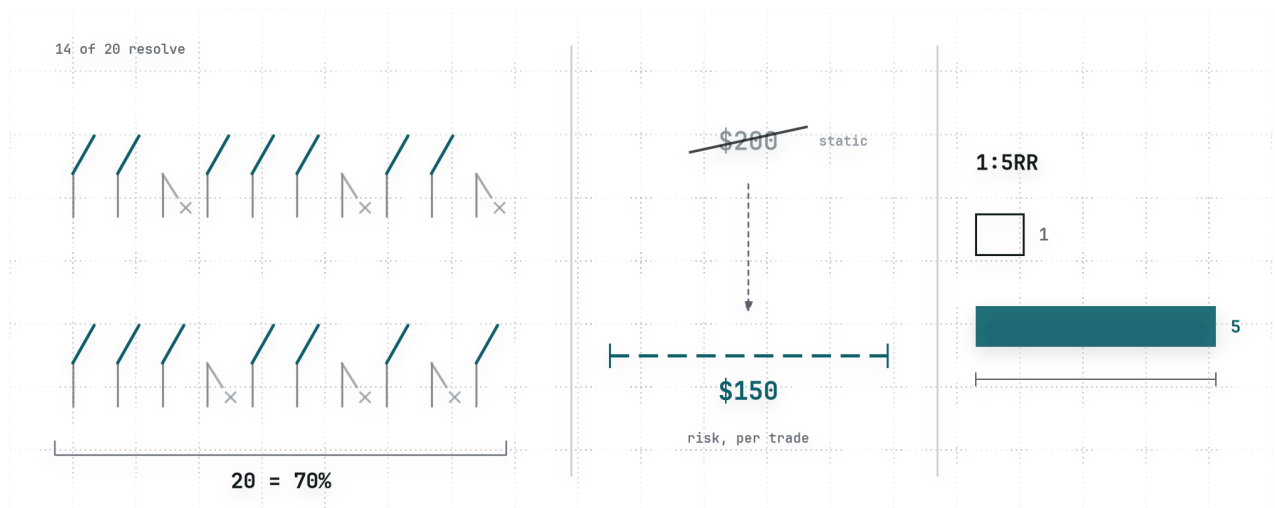




The Average Unprofitable Trader

A case study and the blueprint out of it

SIRES x ETHOS ORDER FLOW



14 OF 20 RESOLVE. 70% AT 1:5RR. RISK \$150, NOT A STATIC \$200.

How to use this

This PDF is the in-depth companion I promised at the start of the case-study video. It follows one real trader, Keani, through a live diagnosis: his account, his numbers, his answers to my questions, and the blueprint we built to fix what those answers exposed.

A lot of people will skip straight to the checklist page and print it. Don't. A checklist you don't understand is just another thing to ignore at 9:31. Read the case first, because every rule in here was written against a specific mistake you'll probably recognise in yourself. Then walk the flow map once with your own last twenty trades in mind. Only then print the checklists.

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One caveat before you start. This is one trader's account, read live on camera. The academic numbers in the margins are there to show he is normal, and none of it promises you a payout. It's a process document. The process is the point.



Meet the average unprofitable trader

Most people watching a case study expect a disaster story: someone reckless, someone lazy, someone who never learned the concepts. **Keani is not that. He's average, and average is the problem.**

Keani, who goes by Alive, has been trading Nasdaq futures since September 2025, and his path was better than most. A friend steered him away from ICT and into order flow; he joined the Data server, learned AMT from the basics up, moved on to MotiveWave. Daily-chart reference points, the 30-minute TPO, poor highs and poor lows, value. On paper, that's a framework.

But he had a job, which meant he had eval money, and that's where the spiral started. Eval after eval, each one bought on the feeling that this time he knew enough. He went from blowing evals to passing some. And then the sentence that tells you everything:

"Whenever I did pass the evals, I just felt like I got lucky doing it... that I actually didn't deserve it." 01:03

He passed and still didn't trust it, and he knew he couldn't prove it either way. That feeling, **"I got lucky and I can't prove otherwise,"** is the actual subject of this PDF. Everything that follows is about replacing it with data.



The evidence on the wall



The case on the wall: a real trader's trade log and account dashboard pinned under the title card. Every claim in this document is read off these two screenshots, so you're looking at the same evidence I was.

THE BASELINE POPULATION

The French regulator tracked 14,799 active retail CFD and forex clients over four years: about 84% lost in any single year, rising to 89.4% cumulated over the full four, with an average result of minus 10,887 euros per client. More screen time without a process change made the outcome worse. The same shape as the eval spiral. *AMF, retail CFD and forex study in France, 13 Oct 2014*



The tape doesn't lie: his numbers

Keani would have told you his main problem was psychology. His dashboard said something colder. When we pulled his stats up live, three numbers did all the talking.

\$64

EXPECTANCY PER TRADE

1.27

PROFIT FACTOR

\$741 vs \$452

AVG LOSS VS AVG WIN

"Does this seem good to you?" **"No, no, it's horrible."** 20:31

That second line is Keani grading his own account, and to his credit he didn't flinch. Now read the numbers the right way, because most beginners read them backwards. The expectancy is positive, so the account grinds upward on average. But the average loss is 64% bigger than the average win. **His losers cost more than his winners pay.** His cost per unit is higher than his revenue per unit, and the only thing keeping him above water is win rate. One bad week of variance and the structure folds, which is exactly what kept happening to his evals.

Here's the part that should bother you: he didn't know any of these numbers until I showed him. He had been sizing trades, grading setups and blaming psychology for months without once knowing what a trade cost him on average. You cannot fix a cost problem you've never measured. The caveat: one trader, one eval account, a small sample; a mirror to check yourself in, nothing more.

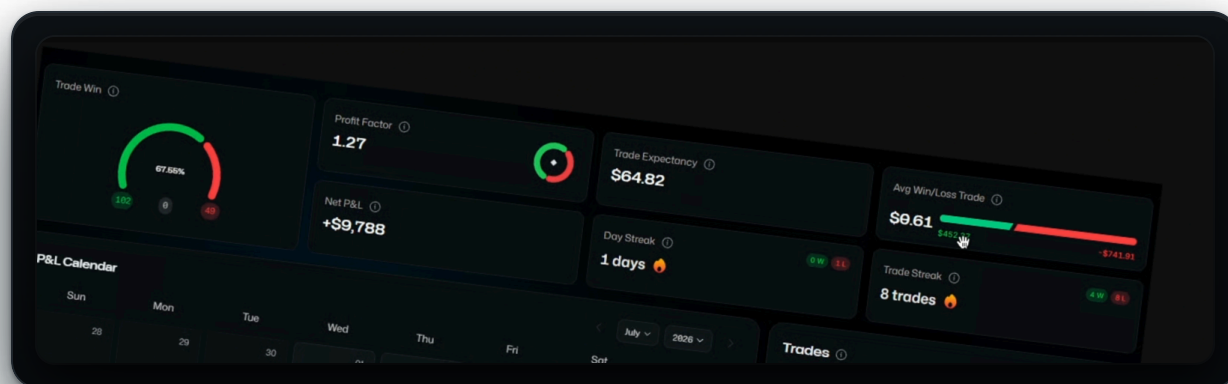
Do you know your own expectancy right now?

If you had to guess your average win, average loss and profit factor without opening a dashboard, that's the same blind spot Keani had. Three live sessions a week walk through reading yours.

Free 7 Day Trial



The dashboard, up close



The top band of his dashboard, zoomed: trade expectancy \$64.82, profit factor 1.27, average win \$452 against average loss \$741.91. The losses are the business cost nobody was tracking, and they dwarf the revenue.

THE DISPOSITION EFFECT

Across 10,000 retail accounts, Odean found investors strongly preferred selling winners and holding losers, and the winners they sold went on to beat the losers they kept by 3.4 percentage points over the following year. Big losses beside small wins is that bias wearing prop-firm clothing. *Odean, "Are Investors Reluctant to Realize Their Losses?", Journal of Finance, 1998*



The red list: four mistakes

Before I drew a single chart in that call, I wrote four things in red, straight out of Keani's own answers in the first five minutes. I'd write the same four for most struggling traders I meet.

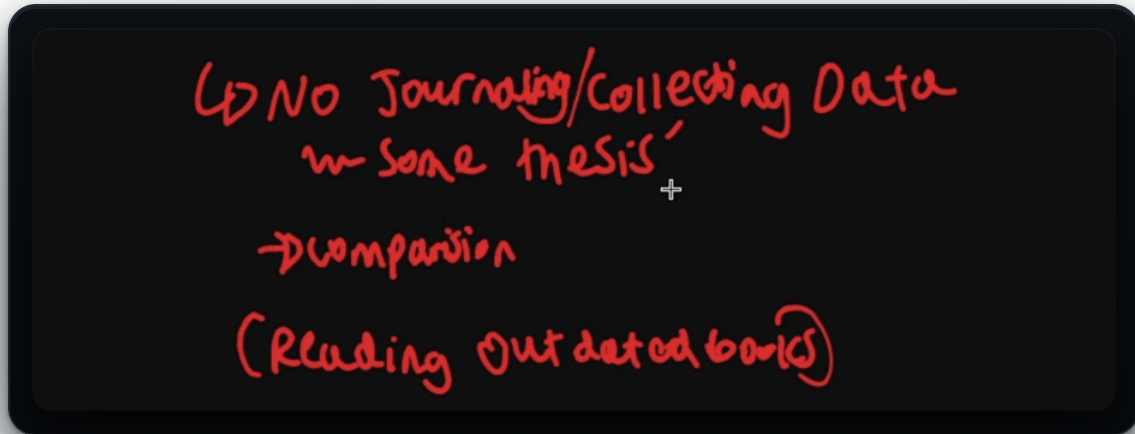
- 01 No journaling, no data collection.** His words: "I don't journal at all." 02:51 His entire data operation was a daily thesis in a Discord, glanced back at a week later. A thesis on a server is an opinion with a timestamp, nowhere near data collection.
- 02 Assumption.** His best winner of the week was a short during a Trump speech: "I just assumed that we would keep going down." 11:33 It paid. He called it luck himself. A trade that wins on an assumption teaches you nothing, and worse, it pays you to keep assuming.
- 03 Outdated books.** Trading books ten, twenty years old, treated as current. Reading feels like work, but trading information is data, and old data ages. Two-decade-stale inputs are competing against inputs from last month.
- 04 Comparison and strategy hopping.** Months wondering how less intelligent traders were outperforming him, switching approach every time the answer hurt. Nobody abandons a strategy they can prove works. Hopping is what the absence of proof feels like from the inside.

"The only reason you would strategy hop is because you don't have sufficient data to even show that your strategy is profitable." 06:36



The red list, on the board

Notice that none of the four is an entry problem. That's the pattern this whole case study keeps returning to.



The first diagnosis, written in red before any chart got drawn: no journal, only loose Discord theses, assumption, outdated books. Four lines, and not one of them mentions entries.

THE UPDATING FAILURE

Using every trade on the Taiwan Stock Exchange from 1992 to 2006, Barber, Lee, Liu and Odean found the vast majority of day traders unprofitable, many persisting despite extensive losses, and over 75% quitting within two years. Their core finding: losing traders fail to update on their own results. A journal exists to fix exactly that. Barber, Lee, Liu and Odean, "Do Day Traders Rationally Learn About Their Ability?", 2017



The psychology myth

Beginners believe losing streaks and over-trading are psychology problems. I want to push back on that hard, because it's the most expensive belief in this whole case. "It's just so easy to blame one, right, which is psychology." 06:23 Psychology is vague, so it absorbs blame without ever producing a fix. Ask the obvious question first:

"You don't data collect. So how do you even know what you're doing is correct in the first place?" 05:54

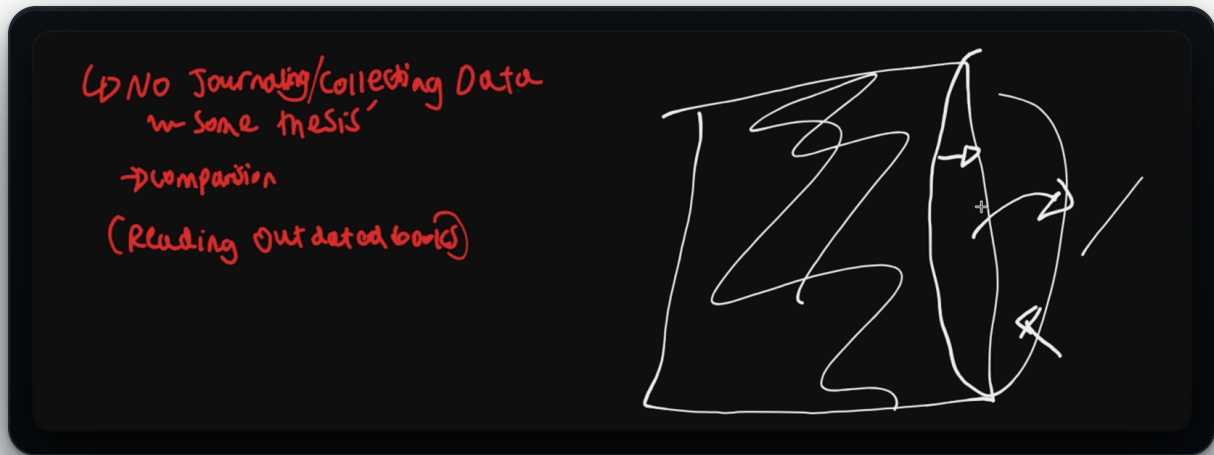
Without data you cannot distinguish a psychology problem from a strategy problem from plain variance. Three losses in a row might be tilt. It might also be a 70% win-rate strategy doing exactly what a 70% win-rate strategy does. You cannot know which without a sample, and blaming your mind is the easiest way to avoid building one.

So here's what you build instead. Picture a box. Inside it is everything your discretionary framework permits: say absorption, exhaustion, trapped buyers and sellers. Outside it sits everything else the market offers: trend lines, support and resistance, the regimes that don't suit you. Inside the box you can act. Outside it, you don't trade, full stop. That boundary is your discretionary barrier, and defining it is the first act of data collection, because you can only measure a strategy that has edges. Once the box exists, noise becomes visible: trading daily-VP shelves off the DOM and randomly switching to footprint imbalances mid-session is noise by definition. Before the box, it just felt like flexibility.

The honest caveat: real psychological pressure exists, and data doesn't delete it. It tells you whether psychology is actually your problem this week. Most weeks, for most beginners, it isn't.



The discretionary box



The discretionary box, drawn while the red list still sits beside it: the market's chaos is tradeable only through the features you've defined inside the boundary. Everything outside gets an X, and the X means you stand down.

NAMED IN 1979

Kahneman and Tversky wrote that a person who has not made peace with his losses is likely to accept gambles that would be unacceptable to him otherwise. That is the break-even trade, named 47 years ago: after a loss the reference point stays anchored, so you accept risk you'd never take flat. *Kahneman and Tversky,*

"Prospect Theory", Econometrica, 1979



Risk that survives you

"Your risk management should allow you to over-trade." 10:10

Read that again, because every influencer tells you the opposite: become a robot who never takes a revenge trade. That's a fantasy. You're human, you will over-trade, and pretending otherwise means your risk plan assumes a person who doesn't exist. Design for the person who does.

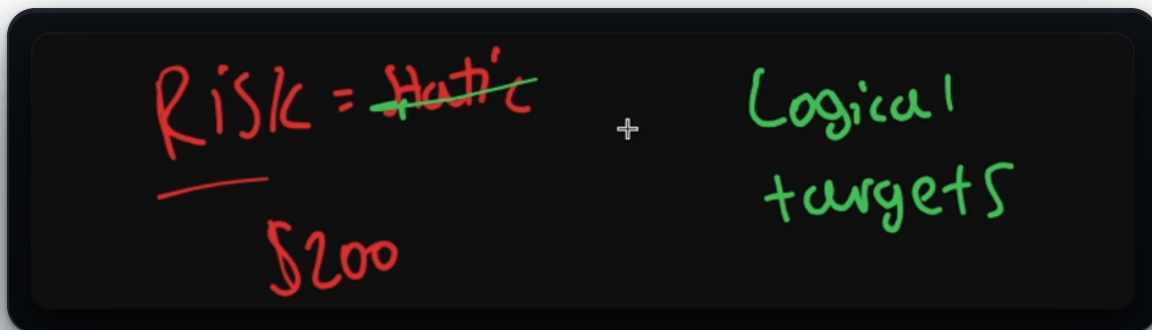
From my own data collection, I know it takes me two to three losses before I notice I've tipped into over-trading: "my risk management allows me to survive those two to three losses." 10:25 So my per-trade risk is sized so that two to three unplanned losses don't matter. The mistake gets absorbed by the structure before I've even caught it. That's the standard: **risk sized for your worst documented behavior**, and you only know your worst behavior if you've collected it.

Now compare Keani's answer when I asked how he sizes: "I risk just based off of, like, in the moment how I'm feeling and what the account needs." 11:58 And the worse admission underneath: when he suspects he's revenge trading, he sizes up. Maximum size at the moment of minimum judgment. Emotions cannot be quantified, so they cannot be a sizing input, ever.

On the board, "static \$200" got the strikethrough. Beginners risk the same dollar figure on an A setup and a C setup, which makes no sense once you say it out loud. Best setups deserve more money, worst deserve less: size flexes with setup quality, while targets don't flex at all, staying where the auction logically pays. Keani had half the instinct already, grading by confluences. What he didn't have was any data proving his grades meant anything. That's the next chapter.



The strikethrough



'Static' gets the strikethrough. Same-dollars-every-trade is the beginner tell: money should flow toward your best setups and away from your worst, while the targets stay wherever the auction logically pays.

PROS DO IT TOO

Studying Chicago Board of Trade proprietary T-bond traders, Coval and Shumway found traders with morning losses about 16% more likely to take above-average afternoon risk than traders with morning gains. Even pros in the pit sized up after a red morning; a rule that survives the impulse is protection. *Coval and Shumway, "Do Behavioral Biases Affect Prices?", Journal of Finance, 2005*



The confluence fallacy

Keani risks more on setups with more confluences, and he believes, like almost every beginner, that more confluences means a higher chance of winning. Nobody ever checks it. So let's check it.

Take two trades. Trade A has three confluences and you risk \$150. Trade B has four and you risk double. Both make complete sense technically. Is the extra risk on B justified? You'd need the hit rate of each, and Keani has neither number. His evidence was memory and old Discord posts. He was doubling his risk on a feeling that the fourth confluence matters.

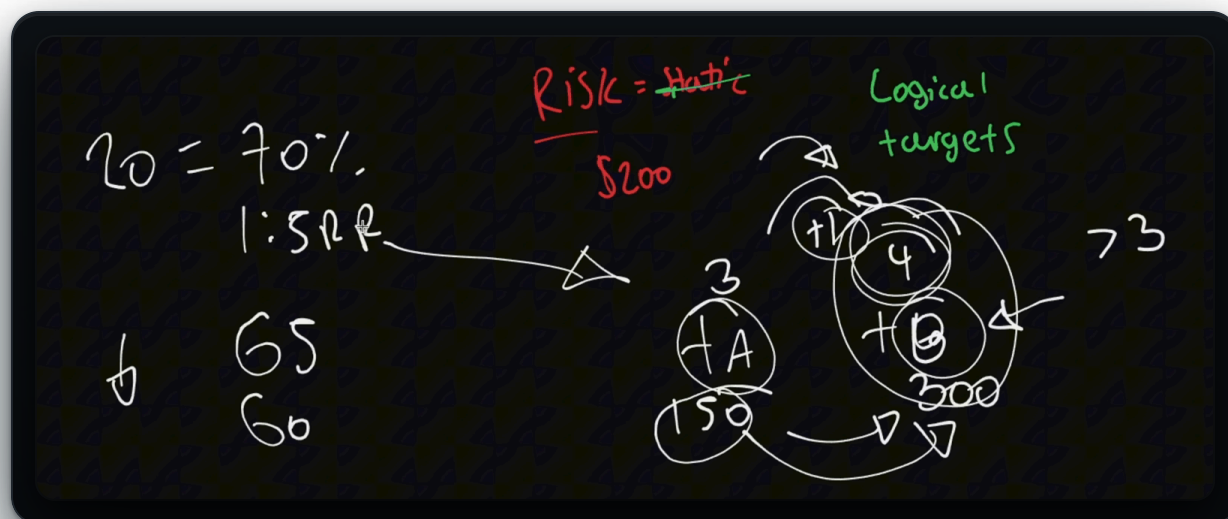
"You're comparing it to nothing, because you have no data backing that hypothesis up." 18:58

Now the worked example from the board, the single most useful piece of math in this PDF. Say you collect 20 trades on three-confluence setups and find a 70% win rate at 1:5 risk-reward. Now demand a fourth confluence. Plausibly the win rate drops to 65%, maybe 60%. How, if the setup got stricter? Because the fourth confluence costs you: time hunting for it, fewer trades taken, good setups going untraded. The stricter filter can genuinely produce a worse account. Or a better one. **You cannot know which until you've collected the 20 trades**, and Keani, months in, had collected zero. His dashboard adds a second cost: his account can't afford lower frequency, so for him specifically, stacking probably makes things worse.

To be fair: sometimes the fourth confluence does raise the hit rate. The fallacy was never in adding confluences. It's in adding them unmeasured.



A against B, on the board



Trade A against trade B: one extra confluence, double the risk, and zero evidence it wins more. The worked example at left shows the fourth confluence dragging 70% down to 65 or 60 while cutting frequency.

THE COST OF ACTIVITY

Among 66,465 US brokerage households from 1991 to 1996, the most active traders earned 11.4% a year while the market returned 17.9%. Activity itself was the cost. Hunting a fourth confluence, like over-trading, spends real money on something never shown to pay. *Barber and Odean, "Trading Is Hazardous to Your Wealth", Journal of Finance, 2000*



The product you actually trade

I asked Keani if he understands how a prop firm works. "No, I don't think so." Most funded traders would have to give the same answer, and it costs them the payout. You think you're trading the market. You're not:

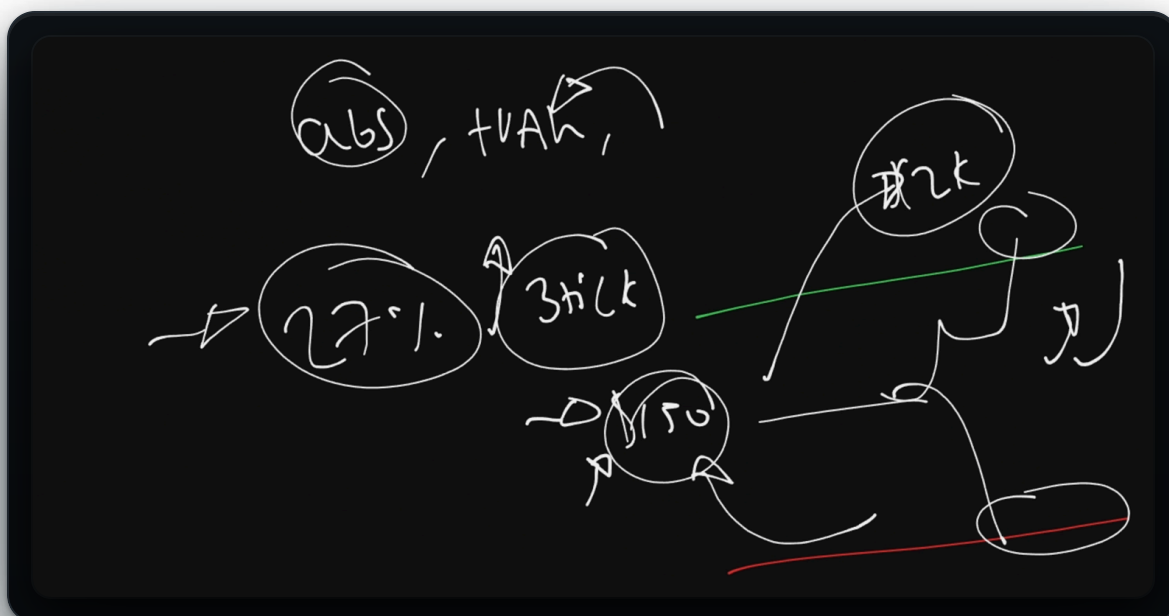
"A prop firm is a synthetic product... You're not actually trading a real-life market. You're trading a barrier-based product." 14:04

A live account sends real orders to the CME. A prop account is a demo with two barriers painted on it: a loss limit below you, a payout threshold above you. Touch one and you're out, touch the other and you get paid. That's the entire game. And the barriers move: an end-of-day trailing drawdown rises with your profit and buffer. The rules are dynamic, so risking a static dollar amount inside a product with moving walls is a category error. You manage risk to the barriers, because the barriers are the product.

Once you see it as a product, the economics invert. You pay roughly \$150 for an account that can pay out \$2,000, so your real maximum loss is the fee. Professional profitability is alpha, and alpha takes maths, statistics, capital and equipment you don't have. Here you don't need it: "You don't need to have a positive expected-value strategy. You only need variance. Your variance has to be profitable." 36:20 About three weeks of technical profitability, repeated: five accounts, three hit the payout barrier for \$2K each, two die for \$150 each, net positive even if the strategy is marginal. The caveat is a big one: variance without process is gambling with extra steps, and none of this guarantees a payout for anyone, ever.



The barrier product, drawn



The barrier product, right: \$150 in, a green path to the payout barrier, a red oval where the account dies. The fee is the only real money on the table, and both barriers move. The circled 27% and 3-tick notes belong to the journaling lesson on page 24.

THE PAYOUT FUNNEL, HONESTLY

Topstep's own 2025 disclosure: 51.8% of participants who entered a Trading Combine reached the Funded Level at least once, yet only 33.3% of funded participants ever received a payout. And firms do pay: FTMO reported \$75,170,210 paid to traders in 2023, while publishing no pass rate at all. The bottleneck is what happens after the pass. *Topstep, 2025 Trader Performance Statistics, Jan 2026 / FTMO blog, 9 Feb 2024*



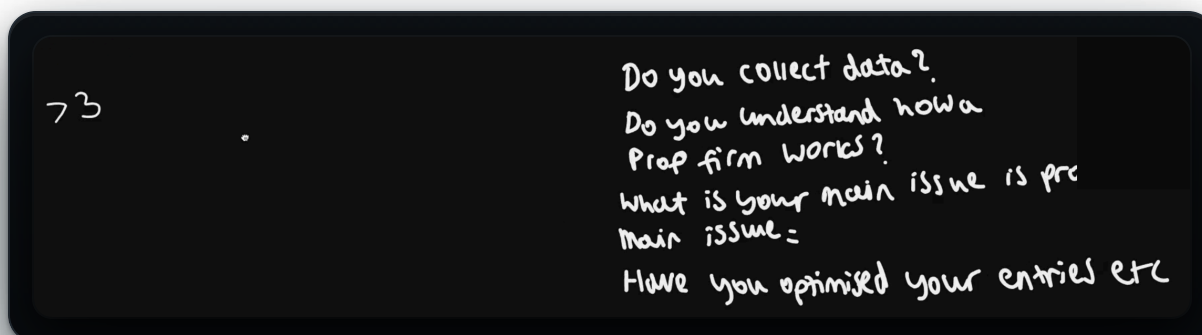
The four questions

Before the interview I wrote four questions on the board. They were the skeleton of everything I asked Keani, and they're the audit I'd hand any struggling trader. Answer them honestly, in writing, before you buy your next eval.

- 01 Do you collect data?** Not "do you think about your trades." Not "do you post a thesis in a Discord sometimes." Do you have, written down, a sample of your own trades tagged by feature, regime and outcome, large enough to answer a question with? Keani's honest answer was no, and if yours is too, every other problem you think you have is unverified. This question comes first because every later question depends on it.
- 02 Do you understand how a prop firm works?** Can you explain, right now, how your account's trailing drawdown moves, where both barriers sit today, and what that implies for your size? If you're risking a fixed dollar amount inside a product whose walls move daily, the answer is no, whatever you'd like it to be.
- 03 What is your main issue? (It's probably not the main issue.)** This is the trap question. Keani said psychology. Nearly everyone says psychology, because psychology is unfalsifiable and flattering: it implies the strategy is fine and only the pilot needs work. But what feels like a discipline problem is usually a data problem or a risk problem casting a shadow. You over-trade because nothing in your risk design absorbs it. You hesitate because you have no sample proving the setup deserves trust. Interrogate the diagnosis before you treat it.
- 04 Have you optimised your entries?** Deliberately last. Entries are where beginners start, and they're the least of it. Optimising an entry inside a strategy with no data, emotional sizing and an unread product is polishing the door handles on a house with no foundations. Once the first three questions have real answers, entry optimisation becomes a measurable A/B test like everything else.



The board, pre-written



The audit, pre-written before the interview started: collect data, understand the prop product, and the trap in the middle. Your main issue is probably not the main issue.

Write your four answers down before turning the page. The rest of the blueprint is what each answer unlocks, in order: the data system, the product maths, the real diagnosis, and only then the entries.

Answered no to more than one?

That's the audit that started Keani's fix. The trial gets you three live sessions a week where I run this same diagnosis on real accounts, plus the full archive.

[Free 7 Day Trial](#)



The data-collection system

"Is journaling the best way to collect data?" Keani asked. The system is smaller and more boring than people expect. Two kinds of data: quantitative, the numbers a dashboard spits out; and qualitative, the written record of what you saw and why you acted. Beginners need the qualitative side first, because it tells you what to count.

It starts with the daily thesis: where are we in the higher-timeframe auction, and who should be in control? Holding a short at the lower boundary of the curve? Possibly not. Buyers step in at a discount. **"Thesis is extremely important, to filter your trades. As a filter."** 22:08

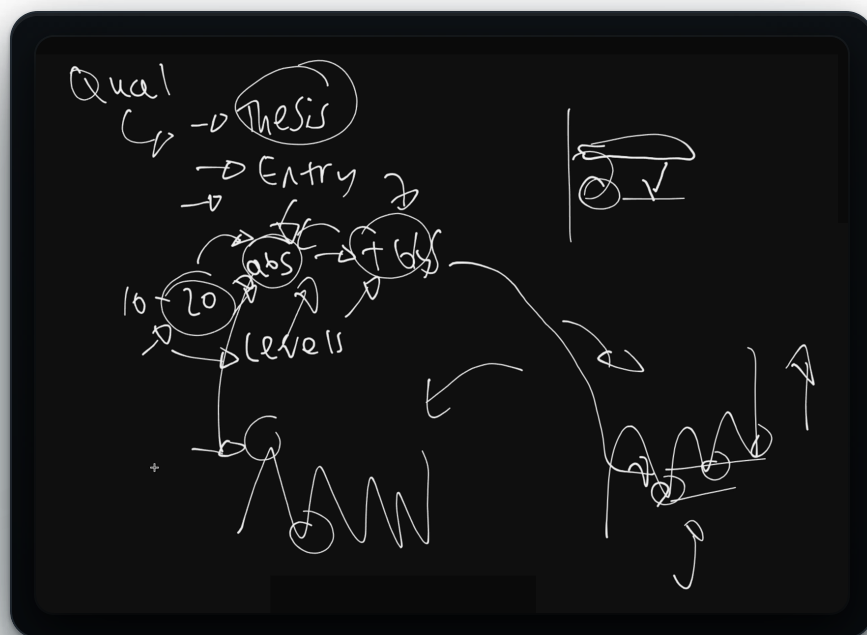
Then entries, and one term worth learning: the **feature set**. Thesis is a feature, entry is a feature; deeper, absorption is one, trapped buyers and sellers another, aggression another. Each is testable. Collect 10 to 20 trades per feature and let the sample declare the winner: absorption against trapped traders, level one against level two, drop the loser. Write the regime down every time, fade or continuation, because features are regime-specific: absorption suits fading a trend; trapped sellers pile up at the bottom of continuation trends.

"Why are you asking me for a subjective judgment? You need to actually look at the day for yourself." 25:18

That was my answer when Keani asked whether his p-day and b-day rule was "good," and I used to ask the same of better traders. Whatever anyone tells you is their judgment on their trades. Collect 20 to 30 of your own; if the rule made no difference, it's noise, drop it.



The qualitative map



The qualitative map: thesis and entry as feature sets, absorption fighting trapped buyers and sellers over a 10-to-20-trade sample, with levels and both regimes sketched underneath. The academic echo: of every Brazilian who day-traded index futures 300+ sessions, 97% lost, with no evidence of learning by day trading (Chague, De-Losso and Giovannetti, 2019). Deliberate loops make screen time teach.



Worked example: open above value

Late in the call, Keani laid out his own setup, and it's worth walking through because it shows what a framework sounds like once the vagueness is squeezed out.

His scenario: the current day's TPO opens fully above yesterday's value, A period sitting clear of the prior value area high. He waits until around 10:00 for the day type to establish from the shape of the profile, then watches the current day's value area high for a break and a retest, entering off the volume profile.

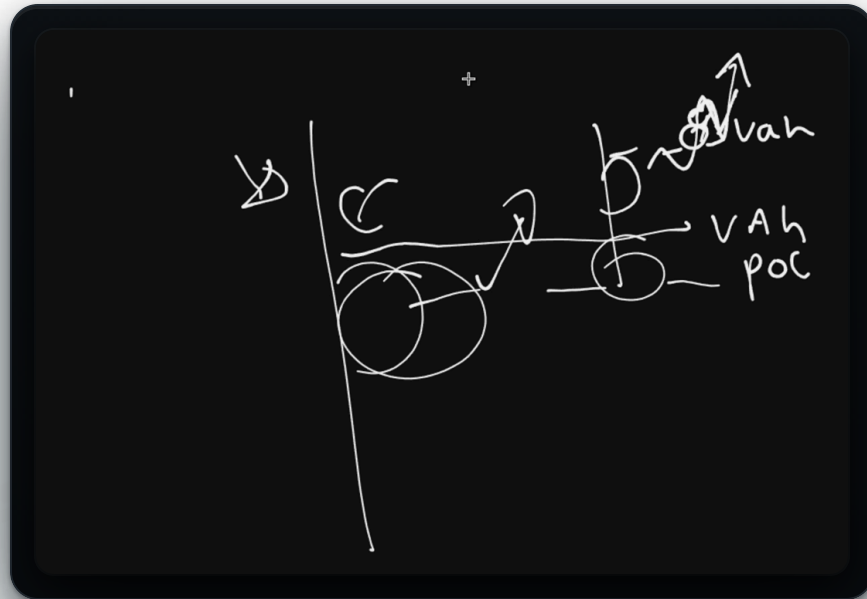
I drew it out, and we validated it through AMT rather than through "does it look good." Sequence matters, so follow it in order. Value opening and building higher is the market telling you buyers are in control and sellers are getting exhausted. Price will probably reject off the POC or the previous day's value area high. Once we're above it and price breaks the current value area high, you should see aggressive buying imbalances doing the breaking. Then the test that decides everything: price comes back to those imbalances. If the buyers who broke the level defend them, that retest is a good long. If they fold, you have your answer, and it cost nothing.

Notice what made the setup good. **Every step is the auction confirming the same story from a different angle:** value shift, rejection, aggressive break, defended retest. No step is decoration.

Now the caveats, because I gave Keani these on the call and they're load-bearing. The trade is still subject to time of day, still subject to what the DOM shows at the retest, and it still needs a decent higher-timeframe objective, somewhere for the auction to actually go. A clean break-and-retest into nothing is a clean entry into a losing trade. Thesis first, always. The entry is the last gate, never the first.



The setup, drawn out



Keani's own setup, validated through AMT: open fully above value, rejection at POC and prior value area high, breakout on aggressive buying, entry on the retest that holds. Every arrow is the same auction story told from a different angle.



How to journal: the recording protocol

People hear "journal" and picture a notebook full of feelings. Wrong tool, and the reason it never sticks. Don't journal on paper. Record your screen for the whole session, then scrub back to the moment just before each entry, pause there, and write what you were thinking at that exact moment.

"What was I thinking before I entered the trade? That is the most important information you'll have." 29:33

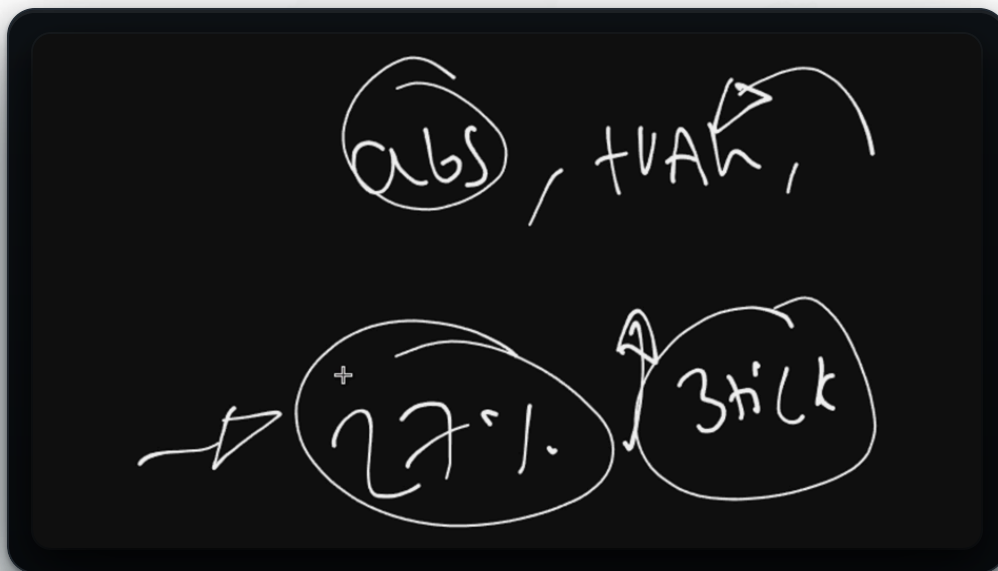
The reason you pause before the entry is lookahead bias. Journal after the trade and the known result poisons the record: "A lot of people think if you win, it's a good trade, when most of the time it's probably a bad trade. Or if you lose, it's a bad trade, but it might be a good trade. It's just variance at that point." 29:51 Keani had been doing exactly this, screenshotting after the close. Every entry in that journal is graded by an outcome variance already decided.



What collection produces

Write it plainly. "Absorption." "Targeting value area high." Why you entered, what happened, how many sellers lost, the volume of the candle. Screenshots in. Money result last; by then it barely matters, because the process is what you're grading. What does collection buy? Hard numbers like this one from my DOM work: absorption fails 27% of the time unless there's a 3-tick aggression toward the absorbed side. A tradeable filter that only exists because the trades behind it were counted.

Two closing points. Tools don't matter: Notion, a journaling site, Discord; collect properly and you can point a folder of screenshots at Claude and have it tell you what you're doing right and wrong, even test your feature sets. And I mean this: **"You need to stop watching content... This is not school. You need to go on the actual charts live and record the videos yourself."** 33:09 Your own recordings will teach you more than any video, including mine.



What collected data looks like: a hard failure rate on absorption, 27% without the 3-tick aggression toward the absorbed side, and the confirmation rule that fixes it. You can only write a line like this after counting your own trades.



The DOM: Location, Pacing, Digits

Beginners come to the DOM looking for a magic entry trigger. There isn't one, and hunting for it is why most people who "trade the DOM" lose. The DOM is three reads, in a fixed order, and the first one isn't even on the DOM.

One: Location. Before you read a single order, know where you are in the auction, because location tells you who should be in control. At the lower boundary of the volume profile, price is at a discount and buyers should step in; price seeks the POC and value 60 to 80% of the time. So you give buyers leniency on the DOM and hold sellers to a higher standard: deciding who gets the benefit of the doubt before the tape starts arguing.

"If you don't understand where we are in the auction, you'll never be truly profitable on the DOM, on the footprint, on any other order-flow entry trigger." 38:35

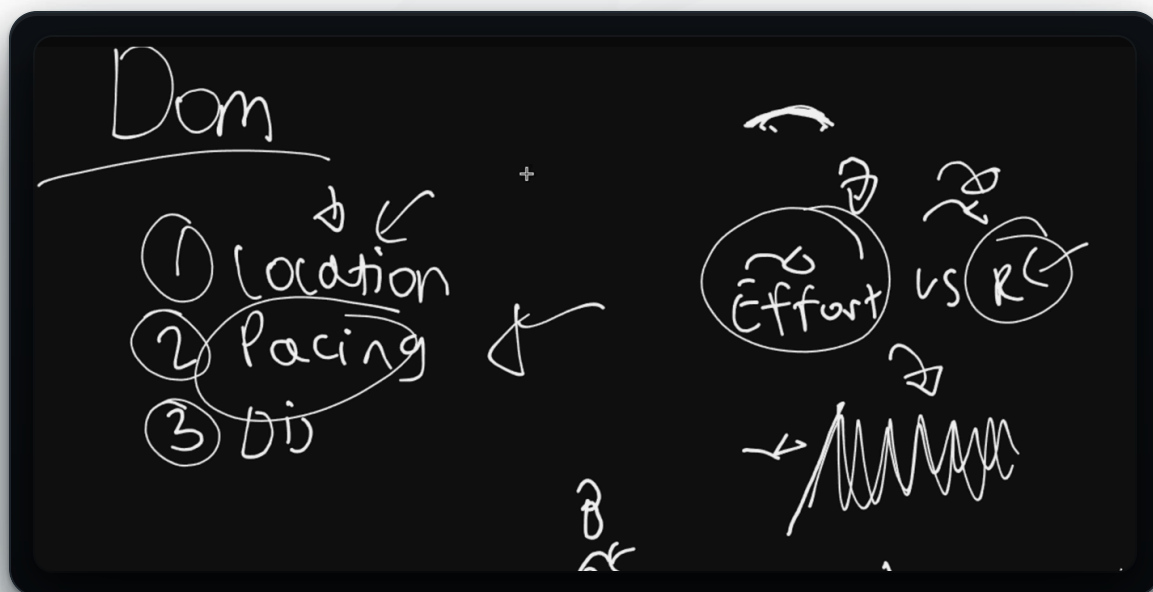


Pacing, then digits

Two: Pacing. Effort against reward. A huge divergence of buyers over sellers while price stagnates, rotating in the same few ticks, is massive effort with no reward, and effort that isn't being paid is a warning, whatever the imbalance says.

Three: Digits. At the open you can't compute bid-ask maths fast enough, so read digit size. Sellers refreshing from two and three-digit sizes down to singles are thinning: weakness. Buyers stepping from two and three digits to four and five are building effort. When the pacing then upticks, effort finally getting its reward, that's the entry.

Location, then pacing, then digits, always in that order, always after the thesis. The reward systems underneath are in the DOM Advanced video. One warning: only your own DOM recordings of your own entries are worth studying. Other people's tape teaches other people's trades.



The DOM in three reads: Location (who should be in control here), Pacing (is effort being rewarded, or is price just rotating, the wave at right), Digits (who is thinning to singles, who is building). In that order, always after the thesis.



The flow map

THE BLUEPRINT

PART 1 OF 2

0

LAYER 0

Define the box, once. Revisit every 20-trade block.

Define the box

Inside: absorption, exhaustion, trapped buyers or sellers on daily-VP shelves. Outside: trend lines, S/R, footprint noise.

Interrogate it

Ask every question you can: DOM or not, reversals or continuations, which sessions, which regimes suit you.

Know the product

A prop firm is a barrier product with dynamic rules. Real max loss = the eval fee. You need repeatable variance, not alpha.

1

LAYER 1

Daily, before any trade.

Check the news

Forex Factory calendar for the day.

Build the daily thesis

Daily chart reference points, then the 30-min TPO profile. Auction location, who should be in control, logical targets.

2

LAYER 2

Per trade, the gate sequence.

A short at the lower boundary of the curve? Buyers should step in. Skip it.

Thesis filter

Agrees with auction location?

YES

Absorption, trapped buyers or sellers, aggression, a level. Fade or continuation regime.

Name the setup

Feature and regime known?

YES

Continues on the next page

Size dynamically, then the DOM confirms, then the target. Turn the page.

NO
STANDNO!
OUTSIDE BOX

No trade. Wait.



The flow map, continued

THE BLUEPRINT

PART 2 OF 2

2

LAYER 2, CONTINUED

Named and filtered. Now size it, confirm it, take it.

Size dynamically

More to the best setups, less to the worst, inside the prop barriers. Never a static figure, never by feel. Risk sized to survive **2-3** unnoticed losses in a row.

An absorption entry needs **3-tick** aggression toward the absorbed side. Without it, it fails **27%** of the time.

DOM confirms

Location → Pacing → Digits

NO
NO ENTRY

No trade. Wait.

YES

Target the logical destination

POC, value, VAH, the poor high or low. Price seeks value **60-80%** of the time.

3

LAYER 3

After the session, same day.

Journal from the recording

Scrub to the moment before each entry and write what you were thinking then, before the outcome. Log feature, target, regime. The money result goes in last.

4

LAYER 4

Every 10-20 trades, the loop.

A/B the features

Absorption vs trapped buyers or sellers. Level 1 vs level 2. 3 vs 4 confluences. Keep the winner.

20 = 70% at 1:5RR

Read the quant sheet

Expectancy, profit factor, win rate, MAE, MFE. Average loss against average win is your cost. If cost beats revenue, fix cost first.

Business review

Eval fees are the cost, payouts are the revenue. Replicate profitable variance across accounts. Then loop back to the box.

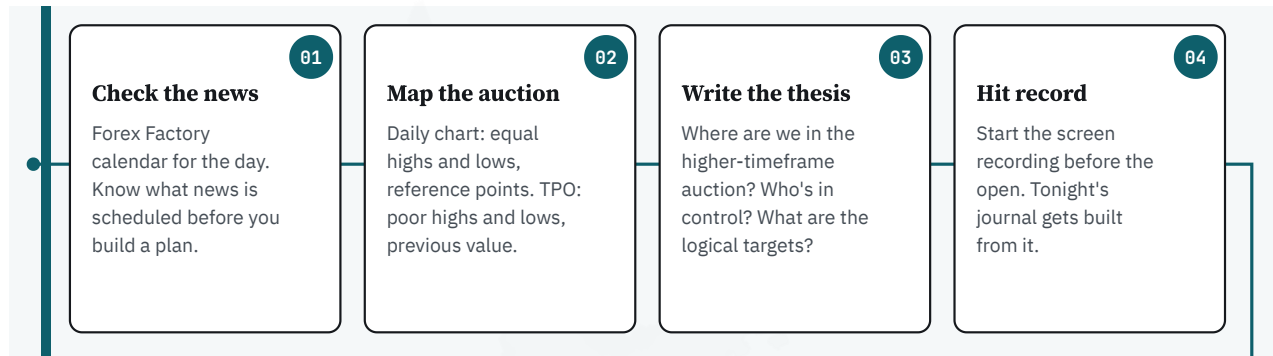
NEXT SESSION → BACK TO PART 1



The flow sheet

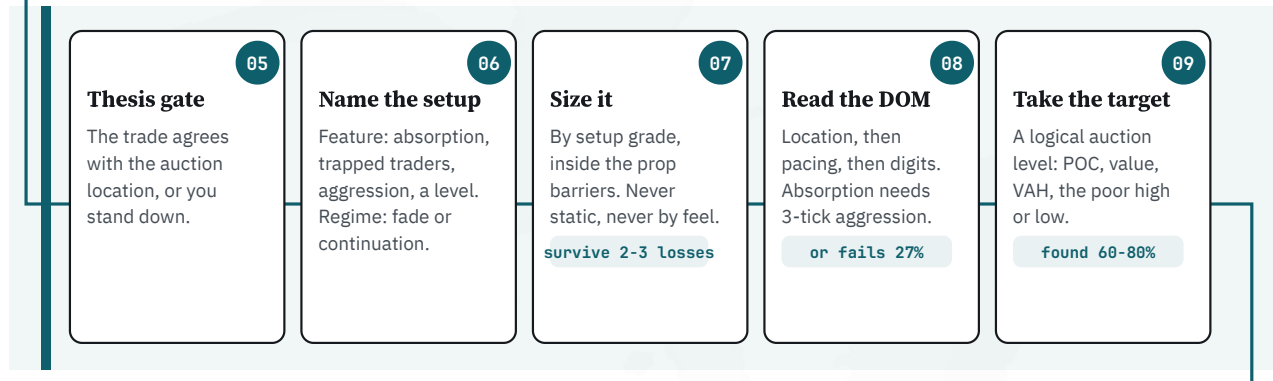
Before the session

pre-market



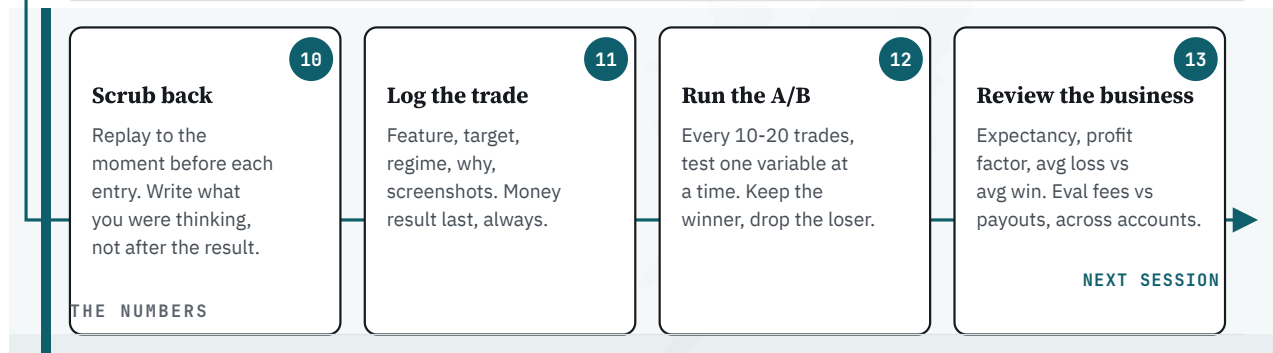
In the trade

the gate sequence, in order



After the session

same day, then per 10-20-trade block

**2-3**

losses your sizing must survive

3 ticks

aggression, or absorption fails 27%

10-20

trades per feature before judging an A/B

60-80%

of the time, price returns to value

\$150→\$2K

the eval product: fee in, payout out



The checklist, printable

Twenty boxes in four blocks. Print this page and stop trusting your memory.

DAILY, PRE-MARKET

- ☐ **Check the news calendar** for the day.
- ☐ **Mark daily reference points:** equal highs and lows.
- ☐ **Mark TPO targets:** poor highs, poor lows, single prints, prior value.
- ☐ **Write the thesis:** auction location and who should be in control.
- ☐ **Start the screen recording** before the session.

POST-SESSION, SAME DAY

- ☐ **Pause the recording before each entry;** write what you were thinking.
- ☐ **Log feature, target, reason, and screenshots** for every trade.
- ☐ **Write the money result last;** never grade trades by outcome.

PER TRADE, IN ORDER

- ☐ **Skip any trade** that fights the thesis or auction location.
- ☐ **Name the entry feature:** absorption, trapped traders, aggression, or level.
- ☐ **Name the regime,** fade or continuation; check the feature fits.
- ☐ **Size by setup grade,** not by feeling or a fixed dollar.
- ☐ **Keep risk inside the prop barriers** and survivable through over-trading.
- ☐ **Run the DOM reads:** location, pacing, digits, in that order.
- ☐ **Absorption entry?** Require the 3-tick aggression first.
- ☐ **Target a logical auction level:** POC, value, or VAH.

EVERY 10 TO 20 TRADES

- ☐ **Tally win rate and RR per feature;** drop the loser.
- ☐ **Test one variable at a time** over 20 to 30 trades.
- ☐ **Read the sheet:** expectancy, profit factor, average loss versus win.
- ☐ **Compare eval fees paid against payouts,** like a business.

Twenty boxes. If one is unticked, the answer is no trade yet. Waiting is free.

Ready to actually run this?

Printing the checklist is step one. Building the daily thesis that feeds it is step two, and that's what unlocks first in the free trial.

Free 7 Day Trial



What this claims, and what it doesn't

Every educational PDF should end by telling you what it can't do. This is a case study of one trader. Keani's \$64 expectancy, 1.27 profit factor and \$741 average loss are one account's numbers, and nothing about a sample of one generalises cleanly. The academic figures in the margins are mostly retail CFD and equity day-trader populations, the closest well-measured cousins to a prop-firm order-flow trader. They describe baselines. They don't predict you.

This document sells no entry edge, because it contains none. The 27% absorption stat is what collection produces, from my sample, on my markets. Yours will differ; that's the whole argument for building yours. The industry numbers deserve their own honesty too: Topstep discloses that only 33.3% of traders who reached the funded level ever received a payout, while FTMO publishes payout totals in the tens of millions but no pass rate at all. Firms pay, and most individuals still don't collect. Both things are true at once.

The two verdicts of the whole case: collect data, and treat the prop firm as a product.

"You're trading blindly at that point, and not blindly as in psychological, but as in data." ^{41:38} Your real loss is the fee: "I'm paying 150 bucks to make potentially 2K, the maximum I'm losing is just the cost I paid up front." ^{42:12} The upside, with repeatable variance and nothing else promised, is technically open-ended. Between the two sits the journal, the 20-trade sample, the loop. Boring, and it's the only part that's real. The flow map, the checklists and the rest of the education library are free at kanji.org.uk.

Questions, DM me or anyone from the video.





Close on the two verdicts: collect data, and trade the prop firm as a product. Everything else in the video hangs off those two lines.

SOURCES CITED IN THE MARGINS

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Collect the data. Trade the **product**.

Those are the two verdicts of the whole case. The filter that makes the data worth collecting is the daily thesis, and thesis creation is the first thing that unlocks in the free 7 day trial, alongside three live sessions a week on NQ order flow and the full archive. Start there, then bring the flow map.

START THE 7 DAY FREE TRIAL

whop.com/ethos-orderflow

Takes two minutes. Cancel in two clicks if it is not for you.

If you skipped here, go back and answer the four questions on page 17 in writing first. Keani answered them honestly on camera. That's the entire reason this document exists.

Ethos Order Flow is an educational community. Nothing in this document or inside Ethos is financial advice, a solicitation, or a promise of profit. Futures trading carries substantial risk of loss and is not suitable for every person. The account statistics herein are one trader's real results, shared in the source video; the academic statistics are published baselines for retail trading populations, cited on the sources page. Past performance does not guarantee future results, and most participants in the cited studies lost money.

Companion reading: *Origin of the Move* and *The Refill Effect*, free at kanji.org.uk

